

From Personal AI Routines to Shared Work

Dependency, Human Agency and Organisational Continuity in AI-Augmented Teams

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Independent Research Concept | Tasneem Fatima | 2026

Motivation and research problem

At Agilibo, I made consequential product decisions while using AI in my own work. Our small startup team developed a SaaS platform for teams in larger organisations. I conducted user interviews and surveys, informed feature decisions including AI assisted sprint planning, and used my own tools, ChatGPT and Grok to organise feedback and clarify user perspectives. A business analyst used AI to draft requirements and technical specifications; developers generated and refined code; an automation test engineer prepared test scenarios before development. Our Scrum Master openly used AI for forecasting, upcoming work and retrospectives.

One experience prompted this proposal. A business analyst deliberately sought my review before finalising requirements and specifications. That preserved human judgment, but progress sometimes depended on my availability and the time needed to review. AI did not necessarily cause the waiting; approval might have been necessary anyway. The question is what changes for colleagues when AI helps someone prepare work: does earlier preparation improve discussion, or does additional checking and explanation shift effort elsewhere?

My 12+ years across enterprise technology, Agile transformation and product management prepare me to investigate this problem through an understanding of organisational workflows, participants' responsibilities and consequential product decisions. These observations motivate a proposed study, not findings from completed research. Professional relationships may support recruitment, but company access and permission to use data are not secured.

I propose to examine when personal AI routines support shared capability and when they concentrate dependencies. A routine may use an approved tool yet remain undocumented or unfamiliar to colleagues. Authorisation, visibility and transferability therefore require separate investigation. The broader concern is how individual AI augmentation becomes collectively usable work: when it expands shared knowledge and human agency, and when it creates dependencies that make work harder to understand, question or continue.

Literature and conceptual approach

Retkowsky, Hafermalz and Huysman (2024) show how individual ChatGPT experimentation becomes integrated into knowledge work, with implications for roles and knowledge relationships. My focus is the work connecting an individual's AI use to other people's responsibilities.

Relational Coordination Theory provides the main analytical foundation. Gittell (2002) examines how relationships and communication coordinate interdependent work under uncertainty. I would investigate whether personal routines support shared understanding and timely problem solving, or make colleagues more reliant on explanations from particular people. The theoretical question is whether AI redistributes the communication and relational work through which coordination is achieved, even when task production becomes faster.

A guiding proposition is that a visible output can circulate more easily than the knowledge needed to assess it. I would examine whether shared goals, knowledge of colleagues' work and mutual respect help teams close that gap through timely, accurate communication. Evidence might instead show that well documented routines reduce explanation needs. The study would therefore examine conditions and mechanisms rather than presume that AI necessarily weakens coordination.

This framing needs attention to authority and visibility. Newlands (2021) examines the strategic visibility of human labour in AI services. Although that setting differs from internal teams, it motivates questions about whose checking and repair work is recognised. Jarrahi et al. (2021) situate algorithmic management within workplace relationships and organisational structures. Together, these perspectives help examine who can question an output, who must justify it, and whether disclosure enables collaboration or exposes employees to disproportionate scrutiny.

I would distinguish repeated prompting, where people select each next step; predefined automation, which executes an arranged sequence; and agentic routines, which select actions or tools within delegated boundaries. These are provisional distinctions, not a maturity ladder. Classification would record actual autonomy, human checkpoints and access requirements, allowing routines to change over time.

Agency and dependency can coexist: requesting a colleague's review exercises judgment while creating reliance on that colleague. Figure 1 provides questions for analysis, not a validated measurement scale. Continuity concerns maintaining useful work through change, rather than preserving every existing practice.

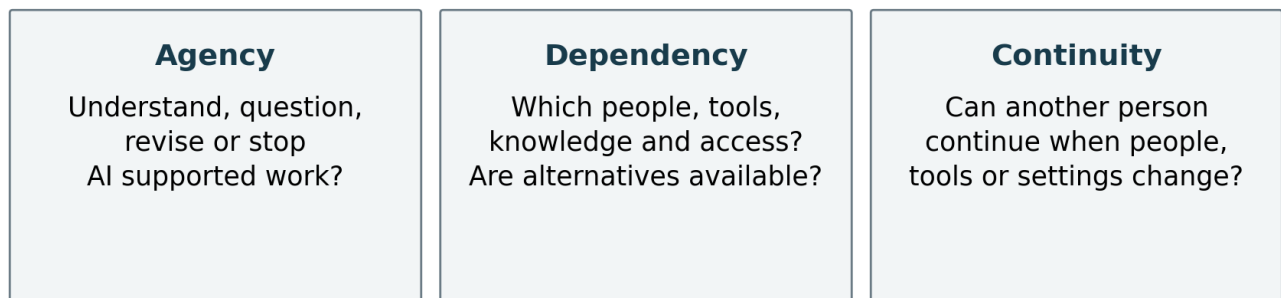


Figure 1. Proposed analytical dimensions informing an agency and dependency diagnostic matrix.

Aim and research questions

Under what conditions do personalised AI routines become useful shared practices, and when do they create dependencies that make work harder to understand, question or continue?

Three subsidiary questions guide the study. How do routines develop and become disclosed or shared? How do they redistribute preparation, verification, knowledge and decision authority? How do teams negotiate review and transfer over time, and how do these processes differ between employee experimentation and formal rollouts?

The unit of analysis would be a collaborative workflow followed over time. Five initial role perspectives would guide recruitment: business analyst, developer, automation test engineer, Scrum Master and product manager. These are starting perspectives, not fixed personas or five separate studies. Evidence would inform subsequent role profiles. Infrastructure or governance staff could explain maintenance and access dependencies without being presumed AI users.

Figure 2 distinguishes primary, secondary and tertiary effects by proximity to AI use, not importance or severity. A product manager may be a direct user when analysing feedback and a downstream reviewer when checking requirements. Roles can move between positions; dependencies and feedback can travel in both directions. Individual, team and organisational levels would be examined across these effects rather than treated as identical categories.

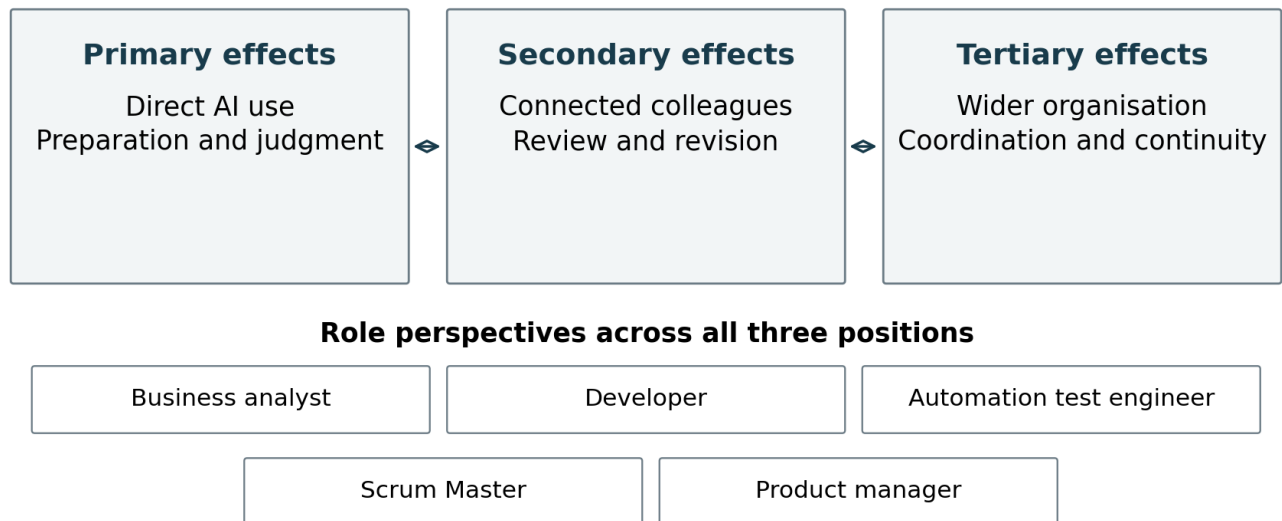


Figure 2. Proposed impact mapping and role perspectives. Connections indicate relationships to investigate, not established causal effects.

Proposed research design

I propose a comparative longitudinal study of two teams undertaking recurring, interdependent knowledge work, with a third case only if feasible. Selection would seek comparable workflows and variation between employee initiated routines and formally introduced AI. These practices may coexist within one organisation. Recruitment would target approximately 12–18 participants across roles, including colleagues who receive AI assisted work without using AI themselves. Final sites, sampling and methods would be agreed with the supervisors.

Initial interviews would reconstruct recent tasks and identify routines, reviewers and decision points. They would explore how organisational culture and trust shape disclosure, willingness to question outputs and expectations of review. Observation of planning, reviews and handovers would establish how work proceeds in practice. AI use would be established through participant accounts and agreed observation, never inferred from polished writing. Each team would contribute a small number of focal routines rather than an inventory of all AI activity.

Across approximately nine months, three interview and network mapping waves would be supplemented by selective observation and short, event based digital diaries. Diaries would flag meaningful changes or review episodes rather than log every prompt. Consented, participant led walkthroughs would then reconstruct selected episodes using redacted artefacts. Optional screen recordings could show how participants check, revise or transfer work; participants could pause recording or demonstrate with a sanitised example. Walkthroughs remain situated accounts and would be compared with observations and artefact histories where available.

For each episode, I would trace preparation, checking, explanation, revision and waiting separately. Approximate time accounts could contextualise effort but would not establish causal productivity effects. Natural changes, such as a colleague's absence, a revised requirement or a tool update, would reveal continuity arrangements without deliberately disrupting work. Similar tasks with less AI involvement would help assess alternative explanations including workload, seniority and pre-existing approval requirements.

Repeated collaboration maps would record whom participants approach for explanation, checking, approval and help continuing a routine. Descriptive changes in these ties could reveal distributed knowledge or concentrated reliance. Network evidence would be interpreted alongside accounts of why relationships changed; small samples would not support population estimates. Missing ties after participant withdrawal would not be interpreted as disappearing dependencies.

Analysis would combine theory informed and inductive coding, followed by within-case timelines and cross-case comparison. Relational coordination would guide attention to shared understanding, communication and respect, while emergent codes would capture unanticipated practices. For each workflow, evidence about benefits, review burdens and authority would be linked to the three analytical dimensions. Contrasting cases, including informal routines that transfer easily and formal tools that create dependencies, would challenge emerging explanations.

To reduce attrition, I would limit diary demands, schedule short follow-ups and recruit across roles rather than depend on one contact. Changes in team membership would be documented. If participation declined, the study would narrow its focal workflows and report evidential gaps rather than substitute new participants as equivalent longitudinal observations.

Ethics and feasibility

The study would require organisational permission and voluntary individual consent. Managers and workers would be interviewed separately, and employers would not receive identifiable accounts of employees' undisclosed practices. Raw prompts, code, customer information and system logs would not be presumed accessible. Recordings would be minimised, redacted and securely stored under an approved retention plan; where recording was unsuitable, participant controlled demonstrations and fieldnotes would be used.

A data management plan would distinguish consent for participation, recording and reuse. Open science outputs could include instruments and analytical procedures; confidential recordings and identifiable organisational material would not be made public.

Agilibo's company and customer data are not offered as a dataset. Recruitment would proceed through approved arrangements, potentially including professional contacts without implying their agreement. My leadership background may improve rapport but also shape interpretation. Reflexive notes, supervision and attention to accounts that challenge my assumptions would address this. Any research involving former colleagues would require particular care around perceived authority and voluntariness.

An indicative programme would begin with literature development, ethics, access and pilot instruments; move into longitudinal fieldwork and preliminary analysis; then deepen comparison, practitioner discussion and theory development before synthesis and writing. Training and writing would run throughout. The exact sequence and duration should be adapted to the host programme, access conditions and supervisory guidance rather than treated as a fixed institutional timetable.

Expected contribution

The study would explain how personal AI capability becomes collectively usable, examining the coordination work that enables or limits that transition. It would investigate whether agency for a creator also supports agency for reviewers and successors. Repeated observations could identify changes in learning, recognition and reliance, while longer-term career effects would remain beyond this study's claims.

A proposed agency and dependency diagnostic matrix would organise evidence by workflow, role and analytical dimension, with continuity assessed during observed changes. It would not assign unsupported numerical scores. Evidence-based role profiles and handover guidance could address ownership, review checkpoints, minimum documentation, version histories, audit trails, access, workflow portability and fallback arrangements. For example, a specification review could reveal whether the reviewer can challenge assumptions, whether essential context remains with its author, and whether another colleague can continue a revision. Comparing such episodes would help distinguish productive interdependence from avoidable concentration of knowledge. Participant discussions would assess the guidance's relevance, not establish universal validation. The broader contribution is to explain when personal augmentation becomes shared capability by connecting AI-supported routines to shared knowledge, human agency and organisational continuity.

References

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